fields. The routine at these dinners was usually the same: After a private reception upstairs, we would descend the grand staircase with the guests of honor, there'd be a receiving line, then Nancy and I would escort them into the state dining room. If the guest of honor was male and married, I sat with his wife beneath Lincoln's portrait, while Nancy sat across the room with the male guest of honor at her table; that way, the guests on one side of the room would not feel any less important than those on the other side. While dessert was served, a group of army violinists known as the Strolling Strings came into the dining room and played; then I'd give a toast, the guest of honor would respond, and we'd go into the Blue Room for coffee followed by entertainment in the East Room. From there, it was into the foyer where a marine band played dance music.

At our state dinner honoring President Pertini of Italy, the Strolling Strings had begun moving among the tables when I saw one of them, a very pretty young woman, stroll very close to Pertini. Since I'd heard this courtly gentleman still had an eye for a pretty girl, I tried to catch Nancy's eye—she was sitting next to him—and smiled at her. Later on, when we went upstairs after dinner, I asked her whether he'd noticed the pretty girl and explained why I'd been trying to catch her eye.

"You've got to be kidding," she said.

"What do you mean?" I asked.

"By that time," Nancy said, "he had already kissed her hand twice."

At a dinner honoring François Mitterrand, he and his wife and Nancy and I finished the receiving line and the four of us walked from the East Room into the state dining room. As was customary, everyone in the room was to stand until Nancy led François to her table and I led Mrs. Mitterrand to my table at the opposite side of the room.